

SJAA Ephemeris Bulletin

✱ Jan 2026

Happy New Year

Welcome to 2026! The year ahead boasts some exciting celestial events, and plenty of SJAA programs returning to bring you closer to the stars.

The Quadrantids meteor shower is well underway, following a great showing of the Geminids last month. On March 3rd, we have a total lunar eclipse that should be visible from Houge Park. It will peak around the auspicious hour of 3:33am, so plan to get up early or stay up late to experience the reddened totality.

The Moon isn't the only body going through a total eclipse this year. The Sun will also reach total eclipse status on August 12th. The path of totality stretches from Iceland to Spain, making it a find excuse for some overseas travel. There's also an annular eclipse in February, but it is probably not worth traveling to Antarctica to view its peak. Save your travel dollars for Iceland or Spain.

On a more local note, SJAA elections are coming up (see below). I heartily encourage anyone who is interested in our official positions to throw their hat in the ring. There are plenty of other, non-elected leadership opportunities, as well. A great way to find out about them is to email volunteer@sjaa.net. Thank you in advance, and keep looking up!

Carl Svensson
Vice-President
Ephemeris Editor

Target of the Month - M42

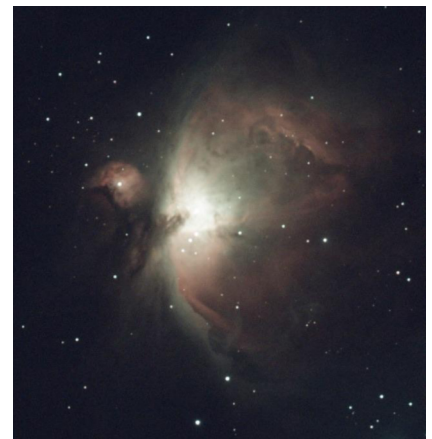
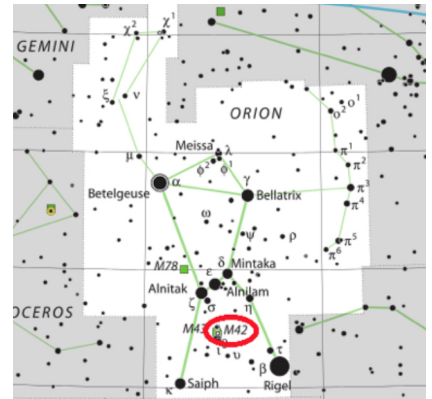
by Joe Fragola

The Orion Nebula, also known as Messier 42, is an emission-reflection nebula located in the constellation Orion, the Hunter. This nebula (Latin for "cloud") is the closest region of massive star formation to Earth, spanning an impressive 24 light years across and containing a mass about 2,000 times that of the Sun. Interestingly, our own Sun was likely born in a similar cloud about 4.5 billion years ago.

Its history of observation dates back to Greek astronomer Ptolemy who cataloged the nebula as a single bright star in 130 AD. So did Danish astronomer Tycho Brahe in the late 16th century and German astronomer Johann Bayer in 1603. Galileo Galilei detected three of the four stars in the Trapezium cluster on February 4, 1617, though the nebula itself was not noted because his telescope couldn't resolve the faint cloud. Charles Messier observed the Orion Nebula on March 4, 1769 and added it to his catalog, though it was already known and discovered earlier by other astronomers.

Within approximately 100,000 years, most of the nebula's gas and dust will be expelled, leaving behind a young open cluster. NASA's Hubble Space Telescope has provided remarkable insights, including a mosaic image released in 2006. This mosaic took 105 Hubble orbits to complete and revealed young brown dwarfs and possible binary brown dwarfs in visible light for the first time.

Magnitude	4.0
Size	24 ly
Object Type	Emission and Reflection Nebula
Constellation	Orion
Distance	1400 ly
Age	3 million yrs



Top: M42 sky chart from theskylive.com. Bottom: Orion Nebula by Joe Fragola on 12-9-2023. Two minutes using Seestar S50 smart scope.

Weekly Updates

You may have noticed a new feature creeping into your inbox in the past month. The SJAA Weekly Newsletter launched in December. It aims to fill the gap between Bulletin issues, keeping members informed without (hopefully) filling up their inboxes. The newsletter features upcoming events and celestial events for the week ahead. This way, you can plan your observing and club activities at the beginning of the week, and never miss a beat. This newsletter (and the Bulletin, for that matter) are a direct result of the member survey that we conducted in the summer, and whose results we featured in the December Ephemeris issue. Please keep an eye out for the newsletter, and let us know any feedback!

2026 Elections

The SJAA election season is upon us! Members should have received an email from Swami, the SJAA Secretary, about upcoming Board and Officer elections. Members are encouraged to consider running for Board and Officer positions. Reply to Swami's email, or reach out to secretary@sjaa.net with your name, history with the club, and why you want to run for the position. The general membership elects the Board members, and Board members elect the Officers. Look for more information, and please cast your vote in the coming months!



SJAA January 2026

Sunday	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday
				1 Giuseppe Piazzi discovers asteroid Ceres  97%	2 Leslie Peltier's birthday George Herbig's birthday Janet Mattei's birthday  99%	3 Board Meeting (IN PERSON) 6:00PM  100% Guest Speaker 8:00PM
4 Solar / Loaner / FixIt 1:30PM Moon 1.3° N of Beehive star cluster  97%	5  92%	6 Regulus 0.5° S of Moon  85%	7  77%	8 Stephen Hawking's birthday  68%	9  58%	10 Starry Nights Star Party 6:30PM Third Quarter Moon Jupiter at opposition  49%
11 William Tyler Olcott's birthday  39%	12  30%	13  22%	14 Antares 0.6° N of Moon  15%	15  9%	16 Astro 101 6:00PM In-Town Star Party 7:15PM  4%	17 Mendoza Ranch Member Observing 5:00PM  1%
18 New Moon  0%	19 Joseph D. Grant Park - Member Observing 5:00PM  1%	20 Imaging SIG 7:30PM  4%	21  9%	22  16%	23 Saturn 4° S of Moon  25%	24  36%
25 Joseph-Louis Lagrange's birthday First Quarter Moon  47%	26  59%	27 Margaret Mayall's birthday Moon crosses Pleiades  70%	28 Mercury 0.7° S of Venus  80%	29 Astro 101 7:00PM Lubos Kohoutek's birthday  89%	30 Jupiter 4° S of Moon  95%	31  99%
			Times and dates are subject to change. Please check sjaa.net and www.meetup.com/sj-astronomy for the latest updates.			
						 Meteor Shower
						 Dark Sky Window